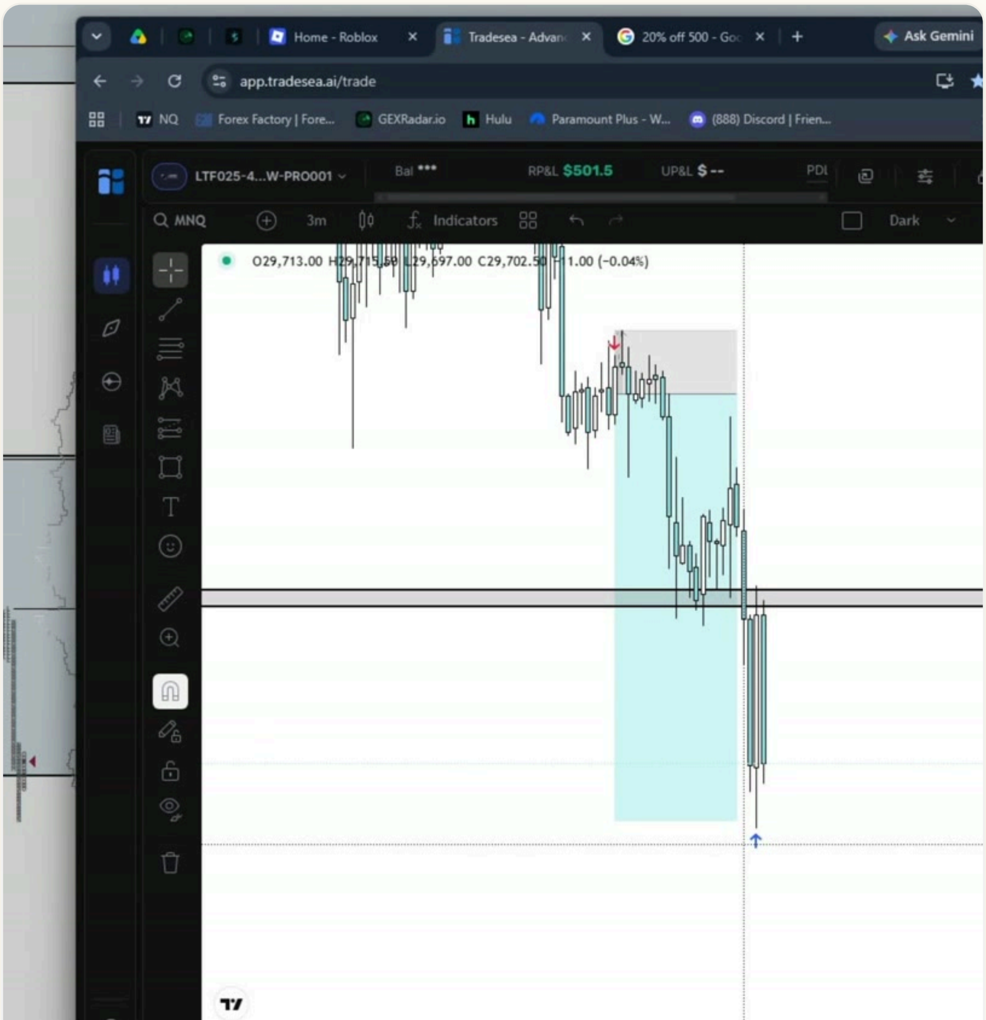
ETHOS ORDER FLOW / EDUCATION

Trapped Buyers, One Retest

A live Asia session trade, read start to finish, off one balance and one Delta print

SAINT × ETHOS ORDER FLOW



Contents

03

The thesis before the bell

a balance readjusted overnight, and price at the edge of it

This is a live Asia session, called in real time, and it starts with a correction to his own read. The balance he had marked the day before did not fit as cleanly as he wanted, so before trading a single contract he pulled it back up and adjusted it lower until it lined up with where price had actually traded. Order flow reads are only as good as the level underneath them, and he treats an ill-fitting balance as a reason to redraw it, not a reason to force the read anyway.

With the balance corrected, the picture was simple: price had already run up into the upper extreme of it. By AMT, an extreme is where the auction is expected to reject, not extend, so his base case going in was a return toward the lower side of the same range. Everything from here is that one idea getting tested against the tape.

> *"Price already approached this upper extreme, and clear AMT tells us we come back lower."*

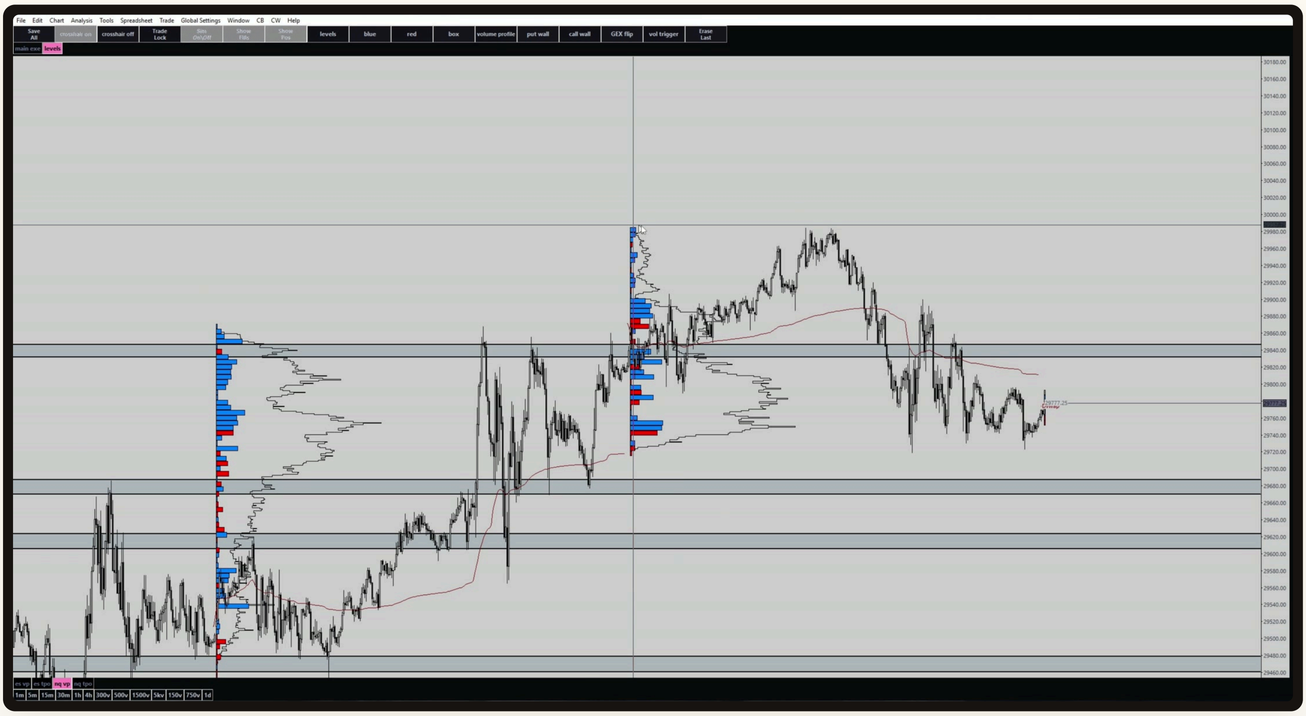
Reading trapped buyers on the Delta

heavy buying into a high can be the reason price turns, not against it

The confirmation came from the daily volume profile with Delta laid over it. At the highs he was watching, the Delta showed heavy buying, and most traders read that as bullish on sight. His read is the opposite, and the logic is what makes it worth writing down.

Buyers who buy into a high and then watch price turn against them are now in a losing position. They did not plan to be trapped, but the moment price fails to keep going their way, they become forced sellers: exiting isn't optional, it's how a losing trade gets closed. A wall of buying at a high, in other words, can be the exact fuel a move lower needs once it starts, not evidence against it. He treats a heavy one sided Delta print at an extreme as a flag to watch for exactly this, not as a reason to join the buyers.

DAILY VOLUME PROFILE WITH DELTA, HEAVY BUYING MARKED AT THE HIGH



Blue bars are buy volume, red is sell, read against price on the same axis. The concentration of blue sitting right at the recent high is the print in question.

05

Twice failed to break higher

what New York's AM and PM sessions were already saying

The Delta read didn't stand alone. Going into the day he had already watched price fail to push above the same upper extreme during both the New York AM and PM sessions. Not once. Twice, at the same level, across two separate sessions, hours apart.

That repetition is the part that matters. One failed push is noise. Two failed pushes at the same price, in two different sessions, is the market telling you where it isn't willing to trade. Combined with the trapped buyers sitting just under that level, the higher timeframe and the order flow were saying the same thing before Asia had even opened: this is not a level buyers were winning at, and every hour it held made a break less likely, not more.

THE LEVEL, DEFENDED TWICE ACROSS TWO SEPARATE SESSIONS

06

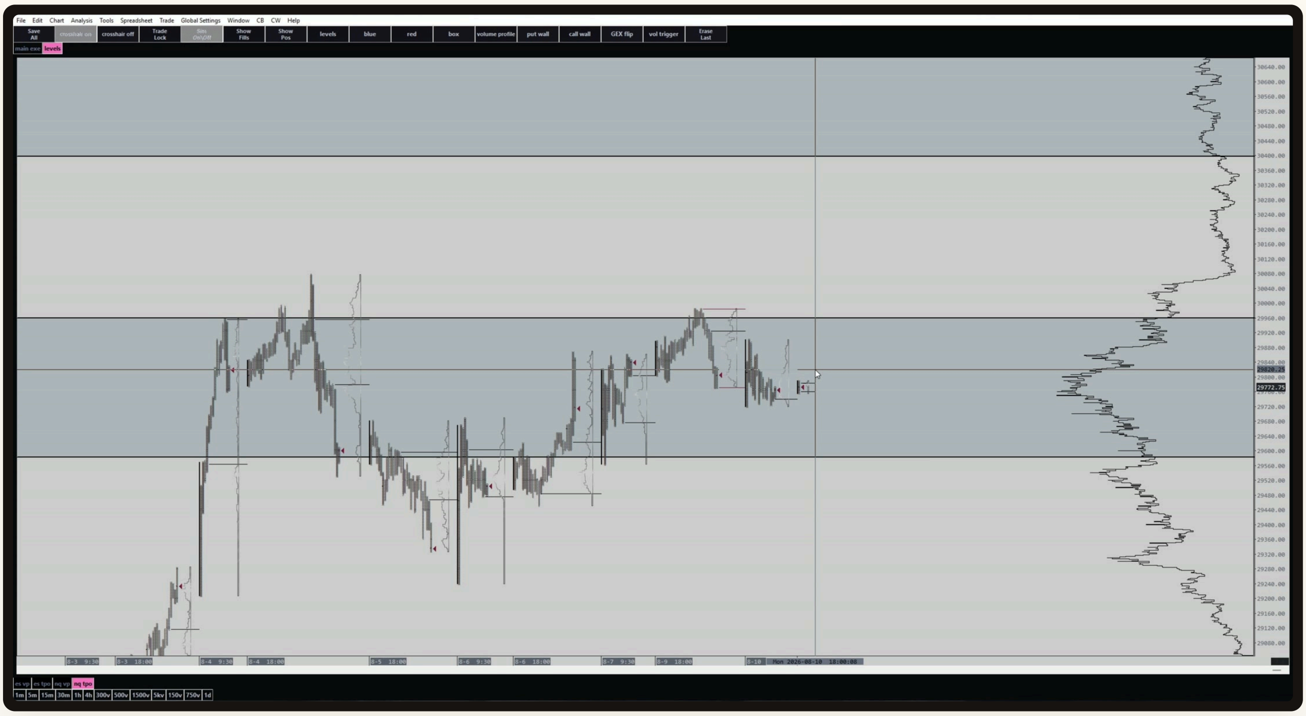
The intraday levels, and waiting for the retest

not chasing the breakout, taking the level it comes back to

With the higher timeframe read in place, he dropped down to the intraday levels built off where the session had opened and balanced. Price pushed up close to the intraday upper extreme without fully tagging it, which by itself was another small piece of the same story: buyers reaching for the level and coming up short of it.

From there the plan was explicit going in, not decided after the fact: wait for a breakout of the intraday range, then wait again for price to come back and retest it. Two waits, not one. If the retest didn't come, the plan was to stand aside and look higher up instead, at the same daily extreme from the first chapter. The entry only existed because the market gave him the second wait, not just the first.

INTRADAY LEVELS MARKED OFF THE SESSION OPEN AND BALANCE



07

The entry

short, off a level that had already been defended once

The breakout came, then the retest came with it. His own words on the fill: "we got that retest right here, we got it, and we shorted all the way down to right here." No hesitation in the clip, because there was nothing left to confirm. Everything from the balance, the Delta, the two failed New York pushes and the intraday breakout had already lined up before price ever got back to the level.

That ordering is the whole discipline of this trade. The analysis happened first, the level was marked before it mattered, and the entry was just price arriving at a decision that had already been made. Nothing here is a reaction dressed up as a plan after the fact.

THE RETEST AND THE SHORT ENTRY, MARKED LIVE

08

Why the target stayed inside Asia's normal range

a bigger number was possible, and deliberately not the plan

The full move toward the lower extreme from the opening thesis was still on the table. He chose not to hold for it. In his own words, Asia sessions tend to run further than people expect, "almost 150 to 160 points" on a session like this one, and while that size was possible, he wasn't willing to risk giving back a confirmed, working trade chasing it.

So the take profit was set well inside that range, closer and simpler, taken as soon as it printed rather than trailed toward the bigger number. This is a sizing decision, not a conviction one: the thesis for the larger move was still intact, he just chose the trade he could defend with confidence over the trade that only works if the extra volatility cooperates.

> **Simple TP, on purpose.** Held for the whole daily range, this same trade could plausibly have paid several times over. Held that way, it also needed Asia's above-average movement to actually show up. He took the version of the trade that didn't depend on that.

09

Reading the tape into the fill

the footprint and the DOM in the seconds around the entry

Zoomed into the footprint, the same story shows up one level lower. Aggressive selling printed inside the candle bodies rather than sitting passively on the offer, and it kept showing up bar after bar rather than as one isolated print. That is the tape agreeing with the higher timeframe read in real time, not just in hindsight.

He checks this specifically because a level can be correct and the entry can still be early. Waiting for the tape itself to show aggression in his direction, on top of the level and the retest, is what turns a good idea into a trade he is willing to size normally rather than half-size on a hope.

FOOTPRINT AND DOM, AGGRESSIVE SELLING PRINTING INSIDE THE BODY

10

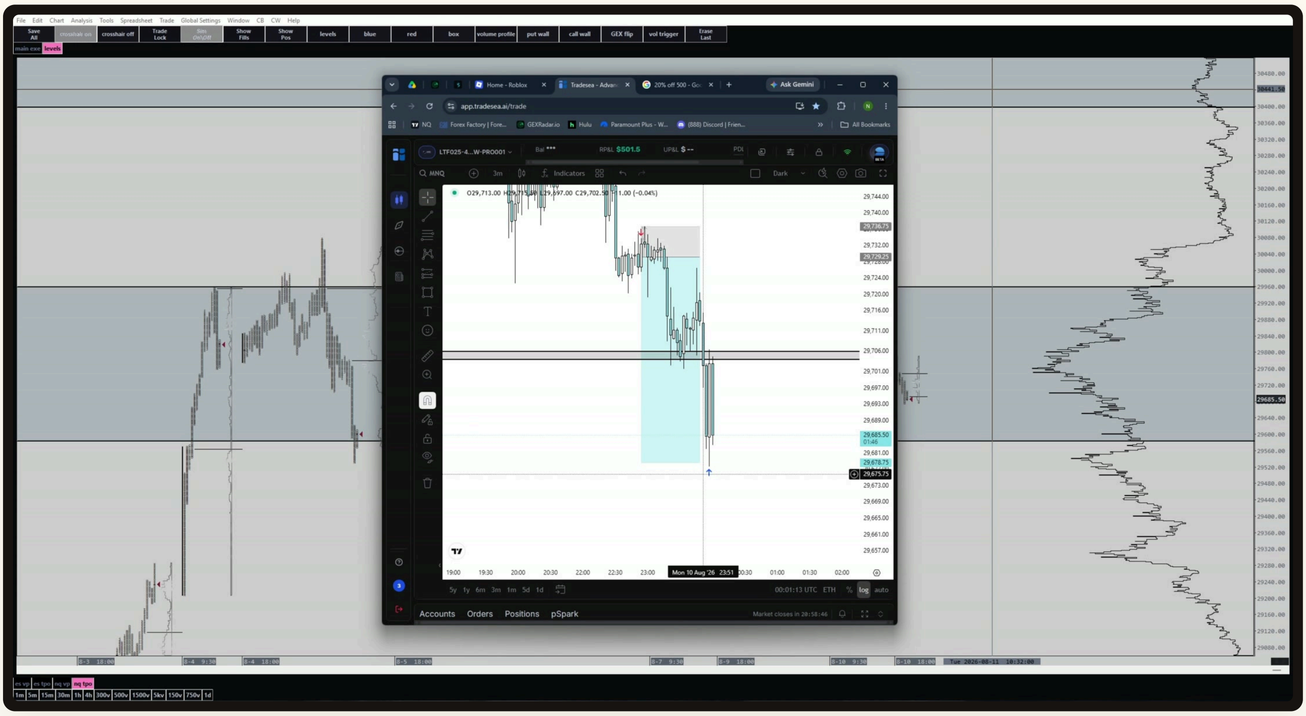
The result

501.50 dollars, and what "to the tick" actually means here

The trade closed at 501.50 dollars realized. He calls the execution "beautiful, to the tick," and on the replay that isn't just enthusiasm: the fill on both ends lines up with the exact levels marked well before either one printed. Nothing about the exit was improvised.

The number matters less than the shape of how it was made. This wasn't a trade sized up chasing a home run figure. It was a normal size, on a level built from three independent confirmations, taken at a target chosen specifically to not depend on an outsized session. Repeatable trades look like this one. Home run trades don't need to.

REALIZED P&L ON THE FILL: $501.50



Read directly off the execution panel rather than off the spoken number, which whisper's transcription of this clip garbled into something unrelated. The panel is the source of truth here, not the audio.

What made it a clean trade

one balance, one Delta read, every confluence agreeing before the entry

Strip the session down and the trade is built from a short list, and every item on it was checked before the entry, not used to justify it afterward: a balance corrected until it actually fit price. An extreme of that balance, reached and not exceeded. A Delta print at that extreme read as trapped buyers rather than strength. Two independent sessions failing to break the same level. An intraday breakout, followed by the retest he waited for rather than chased. And aggressive selling on the tape confirming the level in real time.

His own summary of it: "all confluences came together and turned this into a beautiful trade." None of those six things alone is a signal. Together, in the order they showed up, they are the entire case for the trade.

12

The checklist

every rule in this document, printable

BEFORE THE SESSION

- [ ] My balance actually fits price. If it doesn't, I redraw it before trading off it.
- [ ] I know where price sits relative to the extremes of that balance.

READING THE DELTA

- [ ] Heavy one sided volume at an extreme is a flag for trapped positioning, not automatically a signal in that direction.
- [ ] I've checked whether a prior session already failed at the same level.

THE ENTRY

- [ ] I have a breakout AND a retest, not just the breakout.
- [ ] The tape itself is showing aggression in my direction before I size the trade normally.

SIZING THE TARGET

- [ ] I've decided whether this session's normal range historically runs bigger than my target, and sized accordingly on purpose.
- [ ] My take profit does not depend on above average movement showing up to be worth taking.

One balance.
One Delta read. One retest.

Nothing in this document is a promise about what a trial gets you specifically. It's one teacher's real session, called live, with the reasoning kept in rather than edited down to just the winning fill. The balance, the Delta read, and the wait for the retest were all decided before price confirmed any of it.

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